APPROVED ON OCTOBER 7, 2026
BY THE BOARD OF COUNTY COMMISSIONERS
AT THE WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION - September 30, 2026
9:00 a.m. - Anne G. Basker Auditorium
600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner; Gary Richardson, Commissioner; Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. **CALL MEETING TO ORDER: Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m.**

2. **DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST: Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.**

3. **REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:** *(Each person will be given three (3) minutes to speak)*

Judy Ahrens, Josephine County resident, spoke about public education and student proficiency in reading, mathematics, and science. She expressed concern about Oregon and Southern Oregon test scores, encouraged a greater focus on reading, writing, arithmetic, and cursive handwriting, and urged residents to attend school board meetings and ask how instructional resources are being used.

Ken Cuyler, Chief Financial Officer of Zydevex, introduced the Southern Oregon company and discussed an Oregon Health Authority notice concerning an emerging fungal public-health threat. He stated that the company has patented technology intended to help prevent transmission, described ongoing clinical study of its products, and requested a meeting with the Board, Public Health, and jail health personnel to discuss the technology and possible County use.

Herman Beartreger, Josephine County resident, spoke regarding the proposed jail levy. He objected to comments attributed to him during a recent radio program, stated that he supports funding both the adult jail and Juvenile Justice, questioned the amount of revenue the proposed levy would generate compared with prior levies, and urged the County to consider taxpayer affordability and operating efficiencies.

John Flod, a former Josephine County resident, spoke on behalf of residents of a nearby manufactured-home community. He described substantial increases in space rent, difficulty selling homes, and declining resale values that he said have caused financial hardship for senior residents. He requested the County's assistance in identifying ways to protect vulnerable residents and address what he characterized as wealth loss from the community.

Laurel Keith, a resident of Roegli Estates, described increases in her space rent and concerns about affordability, aging infrastructure, property maintenance, and the ability of residents to retain value in their manufactured homes. She asked for County awareness, resources, and collaboration regarding conditions affecting residents of manufactured-home communities.

Mark Jones, Josephine County resident, commented on the proposed jail levy and referenced prior levy projections. He stated that the current levy proposal would direct most revenue to the adult jail and asked whether the County was pursuing other revenue sources to continue fully funding Juvenile Justice.

4. **BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:**

Commissioner Richardson responded to the education comments by discussing Grants Pass School District 7 reading goals and the distinction between state proficiency measures and workforce-readiness benchmarks. He said he was open to meeting with Zydevex and directed Mr. Cuyler to contact the Commissioners' Office. Regarding manufactured-home concerns, he said the Board has limited direct authority but could explore whether there are ways to assist. He also addressed the jail levy, stating that the proposed $0.93 rate remains unchanged from prior levy rates but that inflation has reduced its purchasing power. He said current projections allow continued funding of adult jail and Juvenile Justice services in the near term, while future budgets will require adjustments.

Commissioner Martin thanked the speakers and supported arranging a meeting with Zydevex. She questioned the stated estimate that the proposed levy would raise $20 million more than prior levies and reviewed recent levy revenue figures,

noting that current projected costs for the jail and Juvenile Justice exceed the amount generated by the levy. She stated the County is examining other revenue sources and budget reductions. Regarding Roegli Estates, she described similar rent increases experienced by a family member and said manufactured-home rent and maintenance concerns involve both private ownership and state housing oversight; she offered to meet with affected residents.

Chair Smith thanked the speakers and asked Mr. Cuyler to contact the Commissioners' Office to arrange a meeting. He stated that manufactured-home rent issues appear to be largely governed at the state or private level and encouraged affected residents to organize, document their concerns, and explore available legal or regulatory avenues. He also commented that County finances are affected by state and federal funding decisions, grants, fees, and inflation.

5. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:

a. Minutes (draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office)

Land Use Hearing – September 21, 2026

Admin Workshop – September 22, 2026

City/County Monthly Update – September 22, 2026

Weekly Business Session – September 23, 2026

Executive Meeting – September 23, 2026

Legal Counsel Update – September 24, 2026

Executive Meeting – September 24, 2026

Executive Meeting – September 24, 2026

Commissioner Richardson moved to approve the Consent Calendar as presented. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

6. OTHER MATTERS: *(ORS 192.640(1) ...Commissioners may introduce other matters for consideration by the entire board)*

Commissioner Richardson reported that, at the September 29 Administrative Workshop, the Board reduced six budgeted Sheriff's Office FTE positions that could not be supported under the current budget and collective bargaining agreements: two Patrol Deputy positions, two Corrections Deputy positions, and two Major Crimes Detective positions. He also highlighted the Josephine County Clerk's property-recording notification service, available through the Clerk's webpage, which allows residents to receive email alerts when documents are recorded under a monitored name or property and may help identify potential fraud.

7. ANNOUNCEMENTS: *(Commissioners may discuss any topic of interest to the general community)*

Commissioners Richardson and Martin reported no announcements. Chair Smith noted that Josephine County was nearing the end of fire season, thanked first responders for their work, and reminded the public to continue exercising caution with fire.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:37 a.m.

Nikole Guzman, Recorder